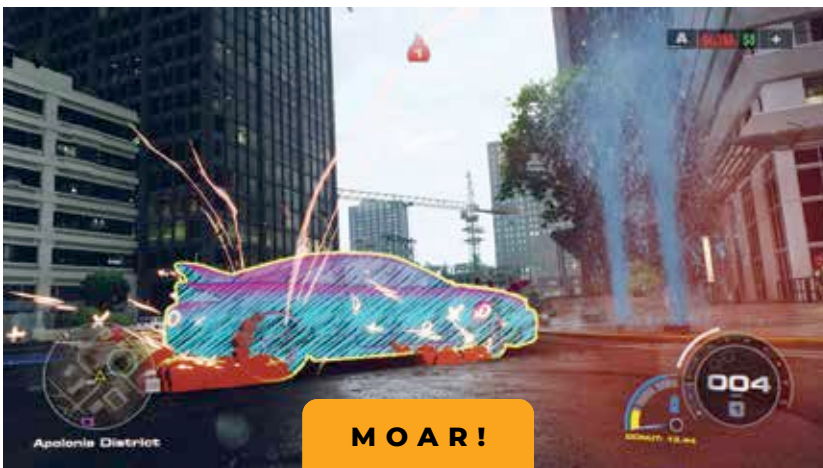




stakes in the city but keeps the car they worked on together. So the mission now is to participate in the illegal races, earn a ton of money, buy new cars and then win back the car they worked on together.

It's a pretty basic story but we were motivated to get out there and race right after the prologue. But then things started to

MOAR!

PUBLISHERS
Electronic Arts

DEVELOPER
Criterion Software

PLATFORM
PlayStation 5,
Xbox Series X and
Series S, Microsoft
Windows

**REVIEW
PLATFORM**
Microsoft
Windows

fall apart. The racing is quite difficult at first because you don't really have a great car and the AI is super competitive even in the easiest setting. Basically, you are not expected to win every (if any) race. That would be fine on its own if you earned enough from the races to tune up your car or buy new cars in order to participate in different

classes of races. But that's not the case. Parts and cars are so exorbitantly expensive that the meagre amounts you earn (or sometimes even make a loss) in races means you have hours of grinding before you can even upgrade your car enough to have any kind of noticeable advantage. And that's a bit of a problem. Having such a gruelling grinding phase so early in a game seems very off-putting. Think about it. You have spent nearly 4K buying this game. You are all excited to participate and win in races. You are excited about all the cool cars you'll get to drive in the game. And just a few minutes into the game you are thrust into a whole world of grinding. It's also a bit disheartening when you are not competitive at all in the races, fighting the backmarkers of a race.

Along with struggling in races, you also have a Heat system where every race you participate in increases your heat level which means you are catching the eyes of the local police. And it only takes a couple of races, for you to have well and truly caught the attention of the cops who will hound you not only in races, which are hard enough as it is, but they will not give up once you are done with your race. And with the underpowered car you have early in the game, it is even more difficult to evade them. The cops in the game are not particularly smart though. All you need to do to evade them and escape is drive around a bit, and make turns that don't have more cops on them (you can see some of them on the mini-map). While it may not be too much effort to evade them, it gets annoying really quickly.

But even that is tolerable when compared to the motivations of the characters you play as. For example, your "friend" who stole everything you had, hosts unsanctioned illegal street races that cause a whole lot of destruction of property – oh, and promotion of dangerous driving. These races are conducted under